

The Corbiani Almanac

MARCH 22 - 28, 2026

*From 84° grilling on the patio to snow-dusted ravioli by
candlelight — seven dinners that prove clarity isn't about calm,
it's about seeing what's actually there.*

 Elsie's No-Go List: Cabbage

Week at a Glance

DAY	EVENTS	DINNER	ALBUM
Sunday 03/22 SUNNY 83°/48°	—	Grilled Chicken Thighs w/ Tabbouleh, Hummus & Turmeric Rice	Lettuce — Unify
Monday 03/23 CLOUDY 70°/36°	Dan meetings 3-8 PM (AI-900 Bootcamp 4-8 PM)	Corned Beef Hash with Fried Eggs & Toast	Common — The Auditorium, Vol. 1
Tuesday 03/24 SUNNY 49°/30°	Dan 1:1s until ~4:10 PM	Babo Pasta (Homemade Spinach Pasta with Egg Yolks)	Lalah Hathaway — VANTABLACK
Wednesday 03/25 SUNNY 59°/36°	—	Lemon Ricotta Pancakes with Berry Compote	Olivia Dean — Messy
Thursday 03/26 SUNNY 67°/47°	—	Chicken & Charred Corn Street Tacos with Elote Crema	Cimafunk — El Alimento
Friday 03/27 SNOW 59°/35°	Elsie early release (End of Quarter 3); YAT + Parents Night Out	Homemade Ricotta-Herb Ravioli w/ Brown Butter Sage (Parents Date Night — Elsie at YAT, gets pizza)	Sheila E. — The Glamorous Life
Saturday 03/28 SUNNY 46°/27°	—	Udon Soup with Premade Soup Dumplings	El Michels Affair — Yeti Season

Daily Plan

*From Middle Eastern grilling to Japanese udon, with funk, soul, and Sheila
E. on the stereo*

Sunday, March 22

Eighty-four degrees in March — the kind of afternoon that sends you straight to the patio with tongs in hand. The grill is hot, the tabbouleh is bright with parsley and lemon, and a week of wild weather begins in the best possible way: outside, together, in the sun.

Grilled Chicken Thighs w/ Tabbouleh, Hummus & Turmeric Rice

MIDDLE EASTERN

Bone-in chicken thighs grilled over high heat until the skin chars and crackles, served alongside bright parsley-heavy tabbouleh, creamy homemade hummus, and fragrant turmeric-tinted basmati rice. A complete Middle Eastern mezze plate that turns Sunday into an outdoor feast.

chicken thighs, bulgur wheat, parsley, tomatoes, lemon, chickpeas, tahini, turmeric, basmati rice

Marinate the chicken in yogurt and spices by noon — the acid tenderizes while the grill heats. Elsie can chop parsley for the tabbouleh.

AT THE TABLE

We're grilling outside in March and it's 84 degrees — it feels like summer crashed the spring party! If you were a weather forecaster, but for feelings instead of weather, what would today's emotional forecast be for our family?

Introduces the week's 'inside weather report' concept through play. The mismatch between March and 84°F is concrete proof that things aren't always what they seem — a natural Stoic opening for an 8-year-old. She's at the age where naming emotions precisely is a superpower she's actively building, and framing it as a forecast makes it feel fun, not therapeutic.

DECISION-MAKING

The Maturity of Trade-Offs: Choosing What Not to Do

You can have virtually anything you want — but not everything. This week explores the strategic art of saying no to good things so the best things have room to breathe.

"If you work hard and think creatively, you can have just about anything you want, but not everything you want. Maturity is the ability to reject good alternatives in order to pursue even better ones."

— Ray Dalio, *Principles: Life and Work* Part II: Life Principles

The Menu and the Meal

Sunday morning and it's eighty-four degrees in late March — an absurd, beautiful gift. The windows are open, the grass is suddenly, impossibly green, and there's a particular kind of energy that comes with warm weather after a long winter: the energy of possibility. You want to start the garden. Deep-clean the house. Take the family on a long bike ride. Batch-cook for the week. Finally fix that leaky faucet. The day stretches out with more possibilities than hours, and the natural impulse is to cram as many in as possible. This is the trap Ray Dalio spent forty years learning to recognize. In *Principles*, he writes: "If you work hard and think creatively, you can have just about anything you want, but not everything you want. Maturity is the ability to reject good alternatives in order to pursue even better ones" (Part II: Life Principles). That second sentence is the one most people skip past, because it's the uncomfortable one. We're trained to believe that ambition means saying yes — to opportunities, to invitations, to the next good idea. Dalio's insight cuts the other way entirely: the mark of maturity isn't the capacity to do more. It's the willingness to do less, deliberately, so that what remains actually matters.

This week, we're going to live inside that idea — not as abstract philosophy but as a practical tool for navigating seven days that include a packed work calendar, a spring quarter wrapping up, weather that swings from eighty-four and sunny to Friday snow, and a rare evening out. Every day will explore one facet of what Dalio calls the trade-off: the strategic art of choosing what not to do. Monday examines why we default to yes and what it costs. Tuesday introduces the mental model that separates goals from desires. Wednesday turns the lens on relationships, where saying no is hardest and most necessary. Thursday applies trade-off thinking to an actual decision on the table. Friday steel-mans the opposition — maybe sometimes the right answer is to say yes to everything. And Saturday closes the loop. Benjamin Franklin put it more simply in 1746: "Dost thou love life? Then do not squander time, for that is the stuff life is made of" (Poor Richard's Almanack). Time, energy, attention — they're the raw materials of every week. What you build with them depends entirely on what you're willing to leave on the table.

"If you work hard and think creatively, you can have just about anything you want, but not everything you want. Maturity is the ability to reject good alternatives in order to pursue even better ones."

— Ray Dalio, *Principles: Life and Work*, Part II: Life Principles

Reflect: Look at your week ahead. What's on the list because you actually want it — and what's there because you haven't given yourself permission to cross it off?

SERIOUS EATS · 4 SERVINGS · PREP 20 MIN + 2 HR MARINATE · COOK 40 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

You make the marinade first. Olive oil, soy sauce, garlic, a little brown sugar, smoked paprika, cumin, a squeeze of lemon. Mix it with your hands, not a whisk. Coat those thighs and let them sit in the fridge at least two hours, overnight if you can. Get the grill hot, medium-high, oil the grates. Lay the chicken down and don't you dare touch it for six minutes. Flip once, cook another six. You want char marks and juicy inside, not rubber. While it rests, toss your tabbouleh with more lemon than you think you need. If your hummus came from a plastic tub, I won't say anything, but I'll know.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

Preheat oven to Grill to medium-high (400-450F)

A · WHISK INTO MARINADE

- 3 tbsp olive oil
- 3 tbsp soy sauce
- 3 cloves garlic (*minced*)
- 1 tbsp light brown sugar
- 1 tbsp lemon juice
- 1 tbsp Dijon mustard
- 1 tsp smoked paprika
- 1/2 tsp ground cumin
- 1 tsp kosher salt
- 1/2 tsp black pepper

B · COAT IN MARINADE, REFRIGERATE 2 HOURS OR OVERNIGHT

- 2.5 lbs bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs (*patted dry*)

Final: Oil grill grates, place chicken skin-side down → Grill 6-7 min per side undisturbed until charred → Internal temp 165F, rest 5 min before serving

VARIATIONS

Za'atar & Lemon Grilled Chicken — Replace the marinade with za'atar, sumac, lemon juice, and olive oil for a tang... (recipe)

Tahini-Honey Grilled Chicken Thighs — Marinate in tahini, honey, lemon, and coriander for a creamy, nutty crust that ... (recipe)

Sumac & Allspice Palestinian-Style Thighs — Season with sumac, Aleppo pepper, allspice, and garlic for a musakhan-inspired ... (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

MARINADE Yogurt-Spice Marinade, 4 Hours Minimum — Mix 1 cup full-fat plain yogurt with 2 crushed garlic cloves, 1 teaspoon cumin, 1 teaspoon coriander, 1/2 teaspoon smoked paprika, the juice of one lemon, 2 tablespoons olive oil, and a generous pinch...

PREPARATION Bloom the Turmeric in Fat Before It Touches the Rice — Heat 2 tablespoons of butter or olive oil in your pot until it shimmers. Add 1 teaspoon ground turmeric, 1/2 teaspoon cumin, and 3 cracked cardamom pods. Stir for 60 seconds until the oil turns deep ...

SAUCE Board Sauce for the Chicken — While the chicken rests (5 minutes, tented loosely — never tightly — with foil), build a board sauce: on a large cutting board, mince together 1/4 cup flat-leaf parsley, 2 tablespoons fresh mint, 1 c...

PREPARATION Hand-Chop the Tabbouleh — Never Pulse — Chop your flat-leaf parsley and mint by hand with a sharp chef's knife — never a food processor. You want clean cuts, not bruised mush. Use a 5:1 ratio of parsley to bulgur. Soak fine bulgur in cold ...

LETTUCE

Unify

2022 · HORN-DRIVEN MODERN FUNK · HORN-
DRIVEN MODERN FUNK WITH JAZZ-FUSION
CHOPS

Lettuce formed at Berklee College of Music in the early '90s, and Unify
(2022) caps a trilogy recorded at Colorado Sound...

*Instrumental funk that arcs from lazy afternoon to peak-hour dance party — no
lyrics to compete with conversation, just pure groove on an 84° patio.*

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Monday, March 23

8 PM | DAN MEETINGS 3-8 PM (AI-900 BOOTCAMP 4-8 PM)

Rain rolls in with a forty-degree temperature drop, and Dan's locked in meetings from 3 to 8 PM. Tonight's dinner needs to be fast, one-pan, and deeply satisfying — crispy corned beef hash with runny eggs is that rescue meal.

Corned Beef Hash with Fried Eggs & Toast

AMERICAN

Crispy-edged cubes of leftover corned beef and golden potatoes, pan-fried in cast iron until deeply caramelized, topped with runny fried eggs that break into a sauce. The kind of dinner that turns leftovers into the best meal of the week.

leftover corned beef, Yukon Gold potatoes, onion, bell pepper, eggs, butter, paprika

Prep the hash before Dan's meetings start. Elsie can crack eggs into ramekins, ready to fry when everyone's hungry.

AT THE TABLE

Rain makes everything look different outside — puddles, reflections, a gray sky that changes the color of everything. What's something in your life that looks one way on the outside but is actually something completely different when you really look at it?

Connects the physical rain to the idea of looking beneath surfaces — the week's clarity theme. At 8, she's developing the cognitive ability to understand that appearances can deceive. This also gently touches on empathy: people may seem grumpy when they're actually tired, or quiet when they're thinking hard. It's a question that rewards slow thinking.

The Yes Tax

It's 2:45 PM on a Monday and in fifteen minutes your first meeting begins. Then another. Then three more. The block runs from three o'clock until eight, and somewhere around 6 PM — when you'd normally be sitting down to dinner, asking your kid about her day — you'll be on your fourth call, nodding at a screen, running on coffee and the fading remnants of your lunch. Each meeting, taken alone, made sense when you accepted it. A quick sync. A planning session. A stakeholder check-in. None of them felt unreasonable. But Naval Ravikant would tell you that's exactly how the trap works. "A busy calendar and a busy mind will destroy your ability to create anything great," he writes in *The Almanack of Naval Ravikant* (Happiness section). The word "destroy" is doing the heavy lifting in that sentence — not "limit," not "challenge," but destroy. Naval isn't being dramatic. He's being precise. Every yes carries a hidden cost he would call the yes tax: not just the hour the meeting takes, but the transition time before and after, the mental residue that follows you home, the creative thought that never forms because the white space it needed was already sold.

The common mistake isn't saying yes to bad things. Nobody schedules meetings they know are useless. The mistake is saying yes to individually good things without accounting for their collective weight. Dalio makes the same point from a different angle: deciding what not to do is as important as deciding what to do (*Principles*, Part II). Most people treat their calendar like a closet — they keep adding until it's stuffed, then wonder why they can never find what they need. The fix isn't superhuman discipline or a productivity app. It's a single question asked before every commitment: if I say yes to this, what am I saying no to? Not in the abstract — specifically. This meeting from five to six means no family dinner. This Saturday obligation means no unstructured morning. This favor for a colleague means the project you actually care about slides another day. When you name the trade-off explicitly, the decision often makes itself. Today, with five hours of meetings stacked like bricks, the tax has already been paid. But tomorrow's calendar is still open. Before you fill it, ask what the next yes will cost — not in time, which is the obvious currency, but in the things time was supposed to buy.

"A busy calendar and a busy mind will destroy your ability to create anything great."

— Naval Ravikant, *The Almanack of Naval Ravikant*, Happiness section

Reflect: Look at tomorrow's calendar. Which commitment would you remove if you had to — and what would you do with the hour you got back?

SERIOUS EATS · 3-4 SERVINGS · PREP 10 MIN · COOK 25 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Cut the potatoes into little cubes, boil them with vinegar and salt until just tender, and drain them good. Melt butter in your heaviest skillet, medium-high. Soften the onions and peppers first, then add the potatoes and press them flat. Now here's where everybody messes up. Stop. Touching. The. Hash. Let it sit and get crispy on the bottom, five, six minutes. Then fold in the corned beef, press it down again, and let it crust up one more time. Top each plate with a fried egg, runny yolk, and good toast. You earned this breakfast.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

A · BOIL POTATOES IN VINEGAR WATER UNTIL JUST TENDER (5 MIN), DRAIN WELL

- 1 large Yukon Gold potato (13 oz) (*1/2-inch cubes*)
- 1 tbsp distilled white vinegar
- 1 tbsp kosher salt
- 1 quart water

B · MELT BUTTER OVER MEDIUM-HIGH, COOK ONION AND PEPPER UNTIL SOFTENED (3-4 MIN)

- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- 1/2 large white onion (3.5 oz) (*unevenly chopped*)
- 1 medium green bell pepper (7 oz) (*diced*)
- 1/4 tsp kosher salt

C · ADD DRAINED POTATOES, PRESS FLAT, CRISP 6-8 MIN UNDISTURBED. FOLD IN CORNED BEEF, PRESS FLAT AGAIN, CRISP 5 MIN MORE.

- 8 oz cooked corned beef brisket (*fat trimmed, diced or shredded*)

Final: Season to taste → Serve with crispy fried eggs on top → Toast on the side, hot sauce optional

VARIATIONS

- Sweet Potato Corned Beef Hash** — Swap Yukon Golds for sweet potatoes and add a pinch of chipotle for a smoky-swe... (recipe)
- Cheesy Baked Hash Casserole** — Transfer the hash to a baking dish, top with cheddar and chives, and bake until... (recipe)
- Kimchi Corned Beef Hash** — Fold in chopped kimchi and finish with sesame oil and scallions for a Korean-Am... (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

- TEXTURE The Cast-Iron Crust Protocol** — Dice your potatoes into 1/4-inch cubes, parboil for exactly 6 minutes until fork-tender but not falling apart, then spread on a sheet pan and refrigerate until completely cold — 30 minutes minimum, o...
- SAUCE Smoked Paprika Butter Baste** — In the last 2 minutes of cooking, add 1 tablespoon of butter, 1/2 teaspoon of smoked paprika, and a few dashes of Worcestershire sauce to the hash. Tilt the pan and spoon the melting, red-tinted butt...
- PREPARATION Crispy-Edged Fried Eggs with Olive Oil** — Forget butter for the eggs tonight. Heat 2 tablespoons of olive oil in a nonstick pan over medium-high heat until the oil shimmers and a drop of water sizzles on contact. Crack your eggs directly in ...

COMMON

The Auditorium, Vol. 1

2024 · CLASSIC BOOM-BAP · CLASSIC
BOOM-BAP WITH JAZZY SOUL SAMPLES

Recorded at Electric Lady Studios in 2024, this Grammy-nominated album came together after Common and Pete Rock connect...

The rain outside, the sizzle of hash in cast iron, and Pete Rock's vintage soul loops — a hunker-down album for a hunker-down dinner. Common's fatherhood stories hit different at the family table.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Tuesday, March 24

4:10 PM | DAN 1:1S UNTIL ~4:10 PM

The sun returns at 49°F — cold but bright, a clean-slate kind of day. It's Tuesday, which means Babo Pasta: the family's weekly ritual of rolling silky green dough while the kitchen fills with the scent of browning butter.

Babo Pasta (Homemade Spinach Pasta with Egg Yolks)

ITALIAN

The family's weekly ritual: silky spinach-green pasta made from scratch with '00 flour, fresh spinach, and a generous helping of egg yolks for that impossibly rich, golden color. Tossed simply with brown butter and Parmigiano-Reggiano — the kind of Tuesday tradition worth protecting.

'00' flour, fresh spinach, egg yolks, whole eggs, salt, butter, Parmigiano-Reggiano

Start the dough before Dan's 1:1s end at 4:10 PM — the resting time lines up perfectly with his schedule.

AT THE TABLE

Every Tuesday we make pasta together — it's our thing. If someone filmed us making Babo Pasta and watched it like a documentary, what would they learn about our family that they couldn't learn any other way?

The ritual of Babo Pasta is so familiar it's become invisible — this question asks her to see it freshly, as an outsider would. At 8, kids are developing theory of mind in more sophisticated ways — understanding how others perceive them. Reflecting on a family ritual from a camera's perspective builds both identity and gratitude for the small, repeated things that actually define a family.

The Five-Step Sieve

Rain is hammering the windows and the temperature has dropped twenty degrees since yesterday. The weather, in its indifference, is demonstrating something you already know but rarely act on: conditions change, and plans that made sense in warmth can look foolish in the cold. This is why Ray Dalio built his entire decision-making system around a distinction most people never make — the difference between goals and desires. In *Principles* (Part II, Ch. 2), he lays out a five-step process: identify your goals, recognize the problems standing in the way, diagnose those problems to their root causes, design a plan to get around them, and execute. Simple enough on paper. But the step most people botch is the first one, because they confuse goals with desires. A desire is "I want to be in great shape." A goal is "I will run three mornings a week before the house wakes up, because cardiovascular fitness lets me keep up with my kid and manage stress at work." The desire floats. The goal connects to something structural — a reason, a system, a consequence. Dalio insists you must "distinguish between you as the designer of your machine and you as a worker within it." The designer decides what matters. The worker follows the blueprint.

The sieve works like this: every request on your time, every project, every "we should really" conversation passes through a single filter — does this connect to a goal I've deliberately chosen, or is it a desire I haven't examined? Desires feel urgent. Goals are usually quieter. The desire to reorganize the garage on a rainy Tuesday afternoon feels productive, but if your actual goal this quarter is to be more present at dinner, spending your one free evening elbow-deep in storage bins isn't serving the blueprint — it's serving the itch. Charlie Munger, who operated a similar mental filter for decades, put it characteristically bluntly: "Knowing what you don't know is more useful than being brilliant" (*Poor Charlie's Almanack*, Ch. 2). Applied to trade-offs, this means knowing which desires are disguised as goals — and having the honesty to name them. Today's cold rain is a gift, if you let it be one. The warm-weather ambitions of Sunday are already fading. What's left when the weather strips away the mood-driven impulses? Those survivors are probably your real goals. Write them down — not ten of them, three. And for the next five days, every time something competes for your time, run it through the sieve: does this serve one of the three, or is it a desire wearing a goal's clothing?

"You have to distinguish between you as the designer of your machine and you as a worker within it."

— Ray Dalio, *Principles: Life and Work*, Part II, Ch. 2

Reflect: Write down your three actual goals for this season — not desires, not wishes, but goals with structure. How many of this week's commitments serve them?

COOKING WITH MAMMA C · 4-6 SERVINGS · PREP 30 MIN + 30 MIN REST · COOK 45 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Thaw your spinach, squeeze every last drop of water out with a towel until your hands are green and tired. Make a mountain of flour with a well in the middle. Crack in the eggs, add the spinach, a pinch of salt, and pull the flour in a little at a time until it becomes a shaggy mess that you knead into silk. Six minutes with the dough hook if you have a mixer, ten by hand. Wrap it up and let it rest, thirty minutes, no peeking. Roll it thin through the machine, cut it however you like, and cook it fresh in boiling salted water for two minutes. Butter, good Parm, maybe some of the pasta water to bring it together. That's Babo Pasta night, and nobody gets to skip it.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

A · MICROWAVE 2.5-3 MIN TO THAW, DRAIN, SQUEEZE WITH TOWELS UNTIL NO LIQUID REMAINS

- 10 oz frozen chopped spinach (*thawed, drained, squeezed bone-dry*)

B · COMBINE FLOUR, SALT, EGGS, AND DRIED SPINACH IN MIXER WITH DOUGH HOOK. MIX ON LOW UNTIL COMBINED, KNEAD ON SPEED 2 FOR 6 MIN.

- 400 g (3 1/3 cups) all-purpose flour (King Arthur preferred)
- 4 extra-large eggs
- 1 pinch salt

Final: Knead by hand 2 min on floured surface until smooth → Wrap in plastic, rest 30 min at room temperature → Cut dough into 4 pieces, roll through pasta machine from widest to setting 4 → Cut into fettuccine or desired shape → Boil in salted water 2-3 min until tender

VARIATIONS

Paglia e Fieno (Straw and Hay Pasta) — Make half the batch with regular egg dough and half with spinach, toss both tog... (recipe)

Spinach Pasta with Walnut Cream Sauce — Blend toasted walnuts with garlic, Parm, and cream into a rich, nutty sauce tha... (recipe)

Spinach Pasta with Bolognese — Pair your green fettuccine with a slow-simmered beef and sausage Bolognese for ... (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

SAUCE Cacio e Uovo: The Egg-Yolk Emulsion — In a bowl, whisk together 3 egg yolks and 1 cup of finely grated Pecorino Romano until it forms a thick paste. Add 2 tablespoons of starchy pasta water — reserved before draining — and whisk until it...

TEXTURE Crispy Garlic-Breadcrumb Pangritata — Tear 2 slices of day-old bread into rough crumbs (or pulse once in a food processor — you want irregular pieces, not dust). In a skillet over medium heat, warm 3 tablespoons of olive oil and add 2 th...

PREPARATION The Pasta Water Protocol — Before you drain the pasta, ladle out a full 2 cups of the starchy cooking water into a heat-safe measuring cup. This is not optional — this water is liquid gold. It contains dissolved starch from yo...

ACID Sharp Fennel-Lemon Side Salad — Shave half a fennel bulb paper-thin on a mandoline (use the guard — I mean it). Toss with the juice of half a lemon, 1 tablespoon of olive oil, a pinch of flaky salt, and a few shavings of Parmigiano...

LALAH HATHAWAY

VANTABLACK

2024 · CONTEMPORARY R&B AND NEO-SOUL
· CONTEMPORARY R&B AND NEO-SOUL WITH
LUSH ARRANGEMENTS

Five-time Grammy winner Lalah Hathaway — daughter of the legendary Donny — released VANTABLACK in 2024, describing it a...

Babo Pasta is a family legacy dish. Lalah carries her father's legacy forward in song. Both are about the warmth of tradition made new — soulful, intimate, worth savoring.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Wednesday, March 25

Midweek arrives at a pleasant 59°F, and the only rule tonight is that there are no rules: breakfast for dinner. The kitchen smells like lemon zest and warm maple, and for thirty minutes, Wednesday feels like Saturday morning.

Lemon Ricotta Pancakes with Berry Compote

ITALIAN-AMERICAN

Cloud-light pancakes made with whole-milk ricotta and bright lemon zest, with whipped egg whites folded in for a soufflé-like rise. Served with a warm blueberry-strawberry compote and real maple syrup — breakfast-for-dinner at its most indulgent.

ricotta, eggs (separated), lemon zest, lemon juice, flour, baking powder, blueberries, strawberries, maple syrup, butter

Separate the eggs and whip the whites to soft peaks — it's the difference between a pancake and a cloud. Elsie is the official berry-compote stirrer.

AT THE TABLE

We're having pancakes for dinner — that's breakfast pretending to be dinner! What's something else that's way better when you put it in the wrong place or at the wrong time — like recess in the morning, or pajamas at the grocery store?

Breakfast-for-dinner breaks a rule in the most delightful way. This question celebrates the joy of things being out of place and challenges her to think creatively about context. At 8, she's internalizing social rules about how things 'should' be — this playfully reminds her that the best stuff sometimes happens when you break the pattern. It also mirrors the week's wild weather, which is March acting like every season at once.

The No That Builds Trust

Your partner asks if you can handle the school pickup Wednesday because they have a work conflict. You're already stretched — your own afternoon is tight, and you know saying yes means rearranging two things and rushing through a third. But you say yes anyway, because that's what good partners do. Right? Brené Brown would challenge you to slow down. In *Dare to Lead* (Ch. 7), she draws a sharp line between what she calls *boundaried generosity* and the kind of giving that breeds resentment: "Clear is kind. Unclear is unkind." The most damaging yes in any relationship isn't the selfish one — it's the resentful one. The one where you agree to something you can't actually absorb, then carry the weight of it as quiet frustration that leaks out sideways at dinner. Your partner didn't ask for a martyr. They asked for help. And the difference between "yes, I can handle that" and "I want to help but Wednesday is brutal — can we figure out another solution together?" is the difference between an obligation and a partnership. The first answer closes the conversation. The second one opens it — and in the opening, something important happens: both people learn what the other is actually carrying.

This is where trade-off thinking gets personal and uncomfortable, because in relationships, the currency isn't just time — it's trust. Dalio's principle that maturity means rejecting good alternatives for better ones applies here with a twist: the "good alternative" is saying yes to keep the peace, and the "better one" is being honest about your capacity even when it's harder. Naval Ravikant makes a similar point about authentic relationships: "You don't have time" is just another way of saying "it's not a priority" (*The Almanack of Naval Ravikant*). That sounds harsh, but it's actually liberating — because if you're honest about your real priorities, your partner can see the actual landscape instead of navigating a polite fiction. Kids learn this too. When you tell your daughter "we can't do that today because I have work," she learns that time has limits and choices are real. When you overcommit and then show up frazzled, she learns that adults say one thing and feel another. The most loving no you can offer someone is the one that comes with the truth attached — not a wall, but a window into what you're actually navigating. It's harder in the moment. It's easier in the decade. And the trade-off is clear: a few seconds of discomfort now, or a slow accumulation of resentment that nobody talks about until it's load-bearing.

"Clear is kind. Unclear is unkind."

— Brené Brown, *Dare to Lead*, Ch. 7

Reflect: Where have you been saying yes when an honest no — with an explanation — would have served the relationship better?

SERIOUS EATS · 4 (ABOUT 12 PANCAKES) SERVINGS · PREP 15 MIN · COOK 15 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Whisk the ricotta, milk, egg yolks, melted butter, vanilla, and lemon zest until it's smooth and smells like a good morning. In another bowl, the flour, baking powder, salt, and sugar get a quick mix. Fold the dry into the wet, gently. Now beat those egg whites to stiff peaks and fold them in like you're tucking a baby into bed. That air is everything. Medium-low heat, butter in the pan, quarter cup per pancake. Wait for the bubbles, flip once, don't press down on them. Serve with warm berries and a little powdered sugar if you're feeling fancy. These pancakes are clouds, honey, actual clouds.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

Preheat oven to Griddle or skillet to medium-low

A · WHISK RICOTTA, MILK, EGG YOLKS, MELTED BUTTER, VANILLA, AND ZEST UNTIL SMOOTH

- 1 cup (8 oz) whole milk ricotta
- 3/4 cup whole milk
- 4 large eggs (*separated (yolks and whites)*)
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter (*melted*)
- 1/2 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 tsp lemon zest (*finely grated*)

B · WHISK DRY INGREDIENTS, FOLD GENTLY INTO WET MIXTURE

- 1 cup + 1 tbsp (141 g) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp kosher salt
- 3 tbsp (45 g) granulated sugar

C · FOLD WHIPPED WHITES INTO BATTER IN TWO ADDITIONS, KEEPING IT LIGHT AND AIRY

- 4 egg whites (reserved from above) (*beaten to stiff peaks*)

Final: Butter griddle, drop 1/4 cup batter per pancake → Cook 2-3 min until bubbles form, flip, cook 1-2 min more → Keep warm in 200F oven while finishing batch

VARIATIONS

Lemon Poppy Seed Ricotta Pancakes — Stir 2 tablespoons of poppy seeds into the batter for a bakery-style crunch tha... (recipe)

Blueberry Ricotta Pancakes — Fold a cup of fresh blueberries into the batter for juicy, fruity bursts that t... (recipe)

Orange Ricotta Pancakes with Mascarpone — Swap lemon zest for orange zest and serve with sweetened whipped mascarpone for... (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Whip the Whites Separately — This Is a Soufflé, Not a Flapjack —

Separate your eggs. Mix the yolks into the wet ingredients with the ricotta, lemon zest, and lemon juice. In a separate clean bowl, whip the egg whites to medium-soft peaks — they should hold their s...

SAUCE Blistered Berry Compote with Balsamic and Black Pepper — Combine 2 cups of mixed berries (blueberries, raspberries, halved strawberries) with 2 tablespoons of sugar and 1 tablespoon of balsamic vinegar in a saucepan over medium heat. Cook until the berries...

TEMPERATURE Honeyed Ricotta Quenelle — Mix 1/2 cup of fresh whole-milk ricotta with 1 tablespoon of honey, the zest of half a lemon, and a tiny pinch of salt. Keep it cold. When plating, use two spoons to form a quenelle — scoop a spoonfu...

OLIVIA DEAN

Messy

2023 · BRITISH POP-SOUL · BRITISH POP-SOUL WITH JAZZY PIANO

Olivia Dean's 2023 debut peaked at #4 in the UK, a breezy, sun-kissed collection of London life painted with Motown war...

Breakfast for dinner is joyful rule-breaking. Dean's music is the sonic equivalent — breezy, bright, and impossible not to smile through.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Thursday, March 26

Spring reasserts itself at 67°F — warm enough to char corn on the grill and eat tacos standing up. Quarter 3 ends tomorrow, the week is cresting, and tonight the kitchen smells like cumin, lime, and charred corn.

Chicken & Charred Corn Street Tacos with Elote Crema

MEXICAN

Cumin-lime marinated chicken thighs, grilled and sliced, piled onto warm corn tortillas with fire-charred corn, cotija crumble, and a smoky chipotle-lime crema. Street food that makes your kitchen smell like a Mexico City mercado — elote vibes in taco form.

chicken thighs, corn (fresh or frozen), corn tortillas, cotija cheese, mayo, lime, chipotle, cilantro, cumin

Dry-brine the chicken two hours ahead. Char the corn directly on the gas burner for authentic elote flavor — the black spots are the point.

AT THE TABLE

Quarter 3 ends tomorrow — that's like finishing a whole chapter of your school year. If your third quarter had a movie title, what would it be? And would it be a comedy, an adventure, a mystery, or something totally different?

End-of-quarter is an abstract adult milestone, but reframing it as a movie title makes it concrete and fun. It invites her to synthesize three months of experience into a narrative — a high-level cognitive task she's now capable of at 8. The genre question reveals how she frames her own experience (comic? dramatic? heroic?) and gives you a window into how she sees her own story.

What Stays, What Goes

The spring quarter ends tomorrow, and that means something is finishing whether you've processed it or not. Projects are wrapping up. Routines that made sense in winter are about to meet warmer weather, longer days, and a different rhythm. The natural impulse is to focus forward — what's next, what should I start, what needs to change. But Charlie Munger would tell you to invert. "All I want to know is where I'm going to die, so I'll never go there," he famously quipped, and while the line is comic, the method is dead serious (Poor Charlie's Almanack, Ch. 2). Before you plan what to add to the next quarter, invert the question: what should you stop doing? What commitment, habit, or project has been quietly consuming resources without returning value — and what would happen if you simply dropped it? This is the part most people skip, because ending something feels like failure. We're conditioned to push through, to "see it out," to honor the sunk cost. But Munger's whole intellectual framework rests on a different instinct: avoiding stupidity is easier than seeking brilliance. Sometimes the smartest move for the next quarter isn't a bold new initiative. It's the courage to kill something that isn't working.

Here's a practical exercise for tonight: make two lists. On the left, write everything you're currently committed to — recurring meetings, personal projects, habits, subscriptions, obligations. On the right, write the three goals from Tuesday's essay. Now draw lines connecting commitments on the left to goals on the right. Anything without a line is a candidate for the cut. This isn't about being ruthless — it's about being honest. Dalio frames this as part of his five-step cycle: after you've set your goals and identified the problems, you design the path forward. But design requires choosing what's in and what's out. An architect who can't decide which walls to remove ends up with a house full of hallways and no rooms. You're the architect of your next quarter, and the blueprint isn't "do everything better." The blueprint is "do fewer things, and do the right ones." Tomorrow the quarter closes. Friday is also your night out — a rare evening of just being two adults instead of two parents, two professionals, two people managing logistics. You earned that evening by getting through the quarter. But what you carry into the next one is a choice you're making right now. Make it deliberately, the way Munger would: by asking not what to add, but what to subtract.

"All I want to know is where I'm going to die, so I'll never go there."

— Charlie Munger, Poor Charlie's Almanack, Ch. 2

Reflect: Make the two-list exercise tonight. What's one commitment you'd quietly drop — and what would open up in its place?

AMBITIOUS KITCHEN · 4 (12 TACOS) SERVINGS · PREP 15 MIN · COOK 25 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Season the chicken thighs with cumin, chili powder, garlic powder, paprika, salt, and a squeeze of lime. Get a cast iron screaming hot with a little oil and sear those thighs until they've got real color, about five minutes a side. While they rest, same pan, throw in the corn kernels and don't stir them for three minutes so they get that black char. Mix your crema: mayo, sour cream, lime juice, chili powder, a clove of garlic grated in. Slice the chicken thin against the grain. Warm your tortillas on the flame, pile them high, drizzle the crema, crumble the cotija, cilantro, done. This is Tuesday night dinner that tastes like a party.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

Preheat oven to Cast iron skillet over high heat

A · RUB CHICKEN WITH SPICES, OIL, AND LIME. SEAR IN HOT CAST IRON 5 MIN PER SIDE. REST 5 MIN, SLICE THIN AGAINST GRAIN.

- 1.5 lbs boneless skinless chicken thighs (*patted dry*)
- 1 tsp ground cumin
- 1 tsp chili powder
- 1/2 tsp garlic powder
- 1/2 tsp smoked paprika
- 1 tsp kosher salt
- 1/2 tsp black pepper
- 1 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tbsp lime juice

B · SAME HOT SKILLET, COOK CORN UNDISTURBED 3 MIN UNTIL CHARRED, TOSS AND CHAR 2 MIN MORE

- 3 ears fresh corn (*kernels cut off (about 2 cups)*)
- 1 tbsp olive oil
- pinch salt

C · STIR TOGETHER INTO ELOTE CREMA

- 3 tbsp mayonnaise
- 3 tbsp sour cream
- 1 tbsp lime juice
- 1/2 tsp chili powder
- 1 clove garlic (*finely grated*)
- pinch salt

Final: Warm 12 corn tortillas on open flame or dry skillet → Fill with sliced chicken and charred corn → Drizzle crema, crumble cotija cheese, top with cilantro and lime wedges

VARIATIONS

Al Pastor-Style Chicken Tacos — Marinate chicken in adobo, pineapple juice, and guajillo chili for a sweet, smo... (recipe)

Baja Fish Tacos with Elote Slaw — Swap chicken for beer-battered white fish and turn the charred corn into a crun... (recipe)

Chipotle-Lime Chicken Tacos with Avocado Crema — Add chipotle peppers to the marinade and blend avocado into the crema for a smo... (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

MARINADE Cumin-Lime Dry Brine, 2 Hours Ahead — Two hours before cooking, pat boneless, skinless chicken thighs dry and season generously on both sides with: 1 teaspoon salt, 1/2 teaspoon cumin, 1/2 teaspoon chili powder, 1/4 teaspoon garlic powde...

TEXTURE Char the Corn in a Dry Cast-Iron Pan — Cut corn kernels off 3 ears (or use frozen, thawed and patted very dry). Heat a cast-iron skillet over high heat with no oil until a drop of water vaporizes on contact. Add the corn kernels in a sing...

SAUCE Proper Elote Crema with Cotija and Smoked Chili — Stir together 1/4 cup Mexican crema (or sour cream), 2 tablespoons mayonnaise, 1/4 cup crumbled cotija cheese, the juice of 1 lime, 1/2 teaspoon chili powder, and a pinch of cayenne. Let it sit for 1...

ACID Charred Tortillas and Quick-Pickled Red Onion — Slice half a red onion into paper-thin rings. Submerge in 1/3 cup lime juice, 1 teaspoon sugar, and 1/2 teaspoon salt. Let sit 20 minutes — they'll turn a screaming magenta. For the tortillas: hold e...

C I M A F U N K

El Alimento

2021 · AFRO-CUBAN FUNK · AFRO-CUBAN
FUNK WITH HEAVY BASS

Cimafunk — born Erik Iglesias Rodríguez, a former medical student from Cuba — made El Alimento (2021) with co-producer ...

An album literally named 'The Food' playing while you build street tacos — Cuban funk and Mexican street food share the same spirit of communal, hands-on joy.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Friday, March 27

ELSIE EARLY RELEASE (END OF QUARTER 3)
YAT + PARENTS NIGHT OUT

Snow falls on the last day of Quarter 3. Elsie has early release, then heads to YAT theater for pizza and friends — which means the kitchen belongs to two. Brown butter, sage, wine, and fresh ravioli made by hand while the world turns white outside.

Homemade Ricotta-Herb Ravioli w/ Brown Butter Sage (Parents Date Night — Elsie at YAT, gets pizza)

ITALIAN

A romantic pasta-making date night: silky all-yolk dough rolled thin, filled with drained ricotta, fresh herbs, lemon zest, and nutmeg, then tossed in brown butter with crispy sage and toasted hazelnuts. Snow falls outside the kitchen window.

00 flour, egg yolks, ricotta, Parmigiano-Reggiano, nutmeg, sage, butter, hazelnuts, lemon

Drain ricotta in cheesecloth for 30 minutes before filling — it's the secret to ravioli that holds its shape in the butter.

AT THE TABLE

You had your own evening tonight with your theater friends, and we had ours. Here's the challenge: describe your evening in exactly three facts — like a news reporter. No opinions, no 'it was so fun.' Just three things that happened. Then we'll do the same for ours.

This is the Stoic 'Fact Game' in action — and Friday is the perfect night for it. After a high-energy YAT evening, she'll naturally want to say 'it was amazing!' Pushing her to describe the facts underneath the fun (what she ate, who she sat with, what happened) builds observational skills and, surprisingly, produces richer stories. It also creates a sweet exchange: she shares her world, you share yours.

The Case for the Full Yes

All week we've been building a case for saying no — strategically, honestly, deliberately. And the framework is sound. But tonight you're going out. Just the two of you. No logistics, no agenda, no optimizing the evening for maximum efficiency. And this is where the trade-off framework needs a pause button, because Peter Thiel would tell you that the most important moments in life don't come from careful filtering — they come from the one time you said yes when the spreadsheet said no. In *Zero to One* (Ch. 1), Thiel asks his famous interview question: "What important truth do few people agree with you on?" Here's one that cuts against everything we've discussed this week: sometimes the right move is to stop selecting and just say yes. To the dessert. To the second glass of wine. To the conversation that goes nowhere productive but somehow leaves you both laughing harder than you have in weeks. The contrarian truth about trade-off thinking is that it's a tool, not a religion. And like any tool used without judgment, it can build a life that's optimized into joylessness — every hour accounted for, every commitment vetted, every spontaneous impulse filtered through a five-step sieve until the fun has been engineered out of it entirely.

Naval Ravikant, who builds his entire philosophy around ruthless prioritization, has a revealing exception: "The secret to a happy life is to have good relationships. That's it" (*The Almanack of Naval Ravikant*, Happiness section). Notice what he doesn't say. He doesn't say efficient relationships, or well-prioritized relationships, or relationships where every interaction passes a trade-off test. He says good relationships. And good relationships require moments of unfiltered presence — evenings where nobody is keeping score, where the only agenda is to enjoy being together. Tonight is that evening. The snow that arrived today makes it feel even more stolen, which is exactly right — the best moments often feel slightly unearned, slightly irresponsible, slightly out of step with the plan. Dalio himself, for all his systems thinking, has said that the people he loves matter more than any principle he's written. The framework we've built this week is a weekday tool. It helps you survive Mondays with five hours of meetings and Tuesdays when rain washes away your plans. But Friday night isn't a weekday problem. Friday night is the reason you endure the weekdays at all. Put the sieve down. Say yes to the evening — not because it's strategic, but because some things matter precisely because they can't be optimized.

"What important truth do few people agree with you on?"

— Peter Thiel, *Zero to One*, Ch. 1

Reflect: When was the last time you said yes to something purely for joy — with no justification, no productivity angle, no plan?

GIADZY · 2 (DATE NIGHT) SERVINGS · PREP 45 MIN + 30 MIN REST · COOK 30 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Make the dough first. Flour mountain, well in the center, crack in the eggs, olive oil, pinch of salt, and pull the flour in slowly until it comes together. Knead it ten minutes, wrap it, let it rest. For the filling, mix your ricotta with Parm, an egg, parsley, basil, a whisper of nutmeg, salt and pepper. Roll the dough thin, thin, thin through the machine. Spoon little mounds of filling two inches apart, brush water around each one, lay the top sheet, press out the air, and cut. Boil them gently, three minutes, they float when they're done. Brown your butter with whole sage leaves until it smells like heaven and the leaves go crispy. Toss the ravioli in, grate more Parm on top. This is date night. You've earned it.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

A · FORM FLOUR WELL, ADD EGGS/OIL/SALT, INCORPORATE GRADUALLY, KNEAD 8-10 MIN UNTIL SMOOTH AND ELASTIC. WRAP, REST 30 MIN.

- 2 cups all-purpose flour (or 00 flour)
- 3 large eggs
- 1 tbsp olive oil
- 1/2 tsp salt

B · MIX FILLING UNTIL JUST COMBINED, CHILL 15 MIN

- 1 cup whole-milk ricotta (*drained if wet*)
- 1/2 cup Parmigiano-Reggiano (*finely grated*)
- 1 egg
- 2 tbsp fresh parsley (*finely chopped*)
- 1 tbsp fresh basil (*finely chopped*)
- 1/4 tsp nutmeg (*freshly grated*)
- salt and pepper (*to taste*)

Final: Roll dough thin (second-to-last pasta machine setting) → Place 1 tbsp filling mounds 2 inches apart, brush water around each → Top with second sheet, press to seal removing air, cut with wheel or knife → Boil ravioli in salted water 2-3 min until they float

VARIATIONS

- Butternut Squash Ravioli with Brown Butter** — Fill with roasted butternut squash, amaretti crumbs, and nutmeg for a sweet, au... (recipe)
- Ricotta Ravioli with Burst Cherry Tomatoes** — Skip the brown butter and toss ravioli with burst cherry tomatoes, garlic, basi... (recipe)
- Ravioli with Brown Butter, Sage & Hazelnuts** — Add toasted hazelnuts to the brown butter sage sauce for a nutty crunch that el... (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

- PREPARATION Ricotta-Lemon-Herb Filling with Nutmeg** — Drain 1 1/2 cups of whole-milk ricotta in cheesecloth for 30 minutes — squeeze out every drop of whey. Mix with 1/2 cup finely grated Parmigiano-Reggiano, 1 egg yolk (not the whole egg — yolk only fo...
- SAUCE Brown Butter with Crispy Sage and Toasted Hazelnuts** — This is a date night, so we're doing the brown butter right. Cut 8 tablespoons of unsalted butter into a light-colored stainless steel pan. Cook over medium heat, swirling, until the milk solids on t...
- PREPARATION Make the Pasta Together — It's the Date** — Set up a pasta station at the counter with two glasses of wine. One person rolls the sheets through the pasta machine while the other fills and seals the ravioli. Make the dough with 2 cups of 00 flo...
- ACID Shaved Parmigiano and Lemon Zest at the Table** — Bring a hunk of aged Parmigiano-Reggiano and a vegetable peeler to the table. Shave 4-5 wide curls over each plate right before eating. Follow with a generous crack of black pepper and the zest of ha...

SHEILA E.

The Glamorous Life

1984 · 80S SYNTH-FUNK · 80S SYNTH-FUNK
WITH EXPLOSIVE PERCUSSION

Prince wrote, produced, and played most instruments on Sheila E.'s 1984 debut, originally intended for Vanity 6. The ti...

Adults-only evening, adults-only album. Synth-funk shimmer that's glamorous enough for date night and groovy enough to dance around the kitchen between ravioli.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Saturday, March 28

*Forty-six degrees and sunny — a forty-degree drop from where the week began.
The kind of cold, bright Saturday that calls for a steaming bowl in your hands
and nowhere to be in a hurry.*

Udon Soup with Premade Soup Dumplings

CHINESE (SHANGHAINESE)

Rich dashi broth poured over thick, chewy udon noodles, served alongside delicate premade soup dumplings filled with seasoned pork and a burst of gelatinous broth that melts into liquid gold when steamed. Served with black vinegar and fresh ginger strips.

ground pork, pork or chicken gelatin stock, flour, ginger, scallions, Shaoxing wine, soy sauce, sesame oil, black vinegar

Build the dashi in the morning — kombu and bonito need time, not attention. The soup dumplings are premade; focus your energy on the broth.

AT THE TABLE

It was 84 degrees on Sunday and 46 today — almost forty degrees different in one week!

What's the biggest change YOU went through this week, from the beginning to right now? It doesn't have to be temperature — it could be a feeling, an idea, or something you learned.

The weather bookends the week perfectly — from extreme warmth to cozy cold. This question uses the temperature swing as a metaphor for personal change and invites her to reflect on her own week with the same clarity the Stoics practiced. At 8, kids are beginning to develop metacognition — the ability to think about their own thinking — and this question exercises exactly that muscle. Over warm udon on a cold day, it's a beautiful way to close the week.

The Stuff Life Is Made Of

A week ago — or six pages ago, depending on how you've been reading these — you stood in eighty-four-degree warmth with a to-do list longer than the daylight. Now it's Saturday, the temperature has crashed, and if yesterday's forecast held, there's snow on the ground in late March. The week didn't go as planned. It never does. But if you've been sitting with this principle — really sitting with it, not just reading and nodding — something may have shifted in how you see the week that just happened. Not everything got done. Some meetings ate time you wanted to spend elsewhere. Some desires masqueraded as goals until Tuesday's sieve caught them. And last night, you put the whole framework down and just said yes. Benjamin Franklin, who thought about time more carefully than almost anyone in American history, landed on a line in 1746 that still hasn't been improved: "Dost thou love life? Then do not squander time, for that is the stuff life is made of" (Poor Richard's Almanack). The word "stuff" is deceptively humble. Franklin didn't say time is the measure of life, or the currency of life. He said it's the stuff — the raw material, the substance itself. You don't spend time on life. Time is life.

So here's what the week's principle comes down to, stripped of frameworks and quotes and five-step processes: every time you say yes to something, you're spending a piece of your life. And every time you say no, you're saving that piece for something else. The trade-off isn't abstract — it's existential. Dalio's maturity test, rejecting good alternatives in order to pursue even better ones, isn't about productivity. It's about the finite, non-renewable, utterly irreplaceable resource of your days. The snow outside is a reminder that seasons turn whether you're ready or not. Spring quarter ended yesterday. Whatever you didn't finish is now firmly in the past, and whatever you choose to carry forward is a decision you're making with the stuff your life is made of. You don't need to remember all seven days of this guide. You don't need the five-step sieve or the two-list exercise, though they'll help if you use them. You just need one question, asked before the next commitment, the next obligation, the next yes: is this worth the stuff? If the answer is yes — genuinely, not reflexively — then give it everything. If the answer is no, let it go. Not with guilt, but with the quiet confidence of someone who knows exactly what their time is for.

"Dost thou love life? Then do not squander time, for that is the stuff life is made of."

— Benjamin Franklin, Poor Richard's Almanack, 1746

Reflect: What is one thing you will protect with your time next week — and one thing you'll finally release?

You can have virtually anything — but only if you stop pretending you can have everything.

JUST ONE COOKBOOK · 3-4 SERVINGS · PREP 15 MIN (+ 10 MIN KOMBU SOAK) · COOK 15 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

I know, I know, this isn't Italian, but a good broth is a good broth and I respect it. Soak your kombu in cold water ten minutes, then bring it up slow, medium heat, and pull it out right before it boils. Drop in the bonito flakes, let them steep a couple minutes, strain everything out. Now you've got dashi. Add soy sauce, mirin, a little sugar, a pinch of salt. Taste it. It should be clean and savory and warm. Cook your udon, steam your dumplings, put it all in a big bowl, pour the hot broth over. Green onions, a soft egg if you want. Simple things done right, that's what good cooking is.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

A · SOAK KOMBU IN WATER 10 MIN. HEAT SLOWLY OVER MEDIUM, REMOVE KOMBU JUST BEFORE BOILING. ADD BONITO FLAKES, SIMMER 1-2 MIN, STEEP 2-3 MIN, STRAIN THROUGH FINE SIEVE.

- 4 cups water
- 1 piece (4-5 inches) kombu (dried kelp)
- 1 cup (loosely packed) katsuobushi (bonito flakes)

B · ADD SEASONINGS TO STRAINED DASHI, WARM GENTLY OVER MEDIUM-LOW, ADJUST TO TASTE

- 2 tbsp soy sauce (usukuchi preferred)
- 2 tbsp mirin
- 1 tsp sugar
- pinch salt

Final: Cook udon noodles per package directions, drain → Steam premade soup dumplings per package directions → Divide udon among bowls, ladle hot broth over → Top with soup dumplings, sliced green onions, soft-boiled egg, nori strips

VARIATIONS

Curry Udon Soup — Stir Japanese curry roux into the dashi broth for a rich, velvety, warmly spice... (recipe)

Kimchi Udon Soup — Add kimchi, gochujang, and sliced pork to the broth for a spicy Korean-Japanese... (recipe)

Miso Butter Udon — Whisk white miso and a knob of butter into the broth for a rich, umami-loaded b... (recipe)

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Build a Proper Dashi Broth from Scratch — Soak a 4-inch piece of kombu (dried kelp) in 6 cups of cold water for 30 minutes — patience, not heat, extracts its glutamates. Bring the pot slowly to just below a boil — you'll see tiny bubbles cli...

TEXTURE Crispy-Bottomed Dumplings — Pan-Fry First, Then Soup — Don't just drop the premade dumplings into the broth — that makes them waterlogged and indistinguishable from the noodles. Instead, heat 1 tablespoon of sesame oil in a nonstick pan over medium-high ...

SAUCE Tare Finish — Concentrated Flavor Bomb at the Bottom — In each serving bowl (before adding noodles or broth), whisk together: 1 tablespoon soy sauce, 1 teaspoon toasted sesame oil, 1/2 teaspoon rice vinegar, 1/4 teaspoon grated fresh ginger, and a pinch ...

TEMPERATURE Soft-Boiled Egg and Scallion Forest — Bring water to a rolling boil. Lower eggs straight from the refrigerator into the water with a slotted spoon. Set a timer for exactly 6 minutes and 45 seconds. Transfer immediately to an ice bath for...

EL MICHELS AFFAIR

Yeti Season

2021 · RETRO-PSYCHEDELIC SOUL · RETRO-
PSYCHEDELIC SOUL WITH TURKISH AND
MIDDLE EASTERN INFLUENCES

Leon Michels recorded Yeti Season (2021) partly during lockdown upstate, where he dressed as a Yeti to entertain his ki...

Cinematic and layered, like watching the week's weather rewind through a kitchen window while broth simmers. Turkish and South Asian textures complement Japanese udon beautifully.

LISTEN ON SPOTIFY

Kitchen & Pantry

Appetizers, salads, and beverages

Appetizers

Reuben Egg Rolls with Russian Dressing

All the glory of a Reuben sandwich — corned beef, Swiss cheese, and tangy sauerkraut — rolled up in a crispy egg roll wrapper and fried until shattering-crisp. Served with homemade Russian dressing for dipping. The best use of leftover corned beef that isn't a sandwich.

Whipped Spring Pea & Ricotta Crostini with Mint

Bright green spring peas and creamy ricotta whipped together with lemon zest, garlic, and fresh mint, spooned onto golden toasted baguette rounds. Finished with a drizzle of good olive oil and flaky salt. Spring on a crouton.

Salads

SIDE

Green Goddess Salad with Avocado, Crispy Chickpeas & Seeds

A generous tossed salad of crisp romaine, shaved cucumber, green onions, and ripe avocado, coated in a vibrant herb-packed Green Goddess dressing. Topped with spiced crispy roasted chickpeas and toasted pumpkin seeds for protein and crunch.

Dressing: Green Goddess dressing: fresh basil, fresh parsley, fresh chives, tarragon, 1 small garlic clove, 2 tbsp lemon juice, 2 tbsp rice vinegar, 1/4 cup Greek yogurt, 1/4 cup extra-virgin olive oil, 1 tbsp white miso paste, salt, black pepper. Blend until smooth and vivid green.

SIDE

Fattoush with Za'atar Croutons & Sumac Vinaigrette

An artfully arranged composed plate: torn pita crisped with za'atar and olive oil, arranged over a bed of little gem lettuce, sliced radishes, cherry tomatoes, Persian cucumbers, and fresh herbs. Drizzled with a bright sumac-lemon vinaigrette. Each component placed intentionally for visual impact.

Dressing: Sumac vinaigrette: 3 tbsp extra-virgin olive oil, 2 tbsp fresh lemon juice, 1 tsp ground sumac, 1 small minced garlic clove, 1 tsp pomegranate molasses, pinch of Aleppo pepper, salt to taste. Whisk until emulsified.

SIDE

Shaved Carrot & Radish Salad with Sesame-Ginger Dressing

Ribbons of carrot and thinly sliced watermelon radish, tossed with a nutty sesame-ginger dressing and sprinkled with toasted sesame seeds and sliced scallions. Light, crunchy, and clean — the perfect counterpoint to rich Asian mains.

Dressing: Sesame-ginger dressing: 2 tbsp toasted sesame oil, 1 tbsp rice vinegar, 1 tbsp soy sauce, 1 tsp freshly grated ginger, 1 tsp honey, 1 tsp lime juice, pinch of red pepper flakes. Whisk together.

Beverage Pairings

Sazerac

The official cocktail of New Orleans: rye whiskey stirred with a sugar cube and Peychaud's bitters, served in an absinthe-rinsed rocks glass with a lemon peel twist. Spirit-forward, aromatic, and deeply satisfying.

New Zealand Sauvignon Blanc (Cloudy Bay or Oyster Bay)

Crisp, zesty, and herbaceous with notes of grapefruit, passion fruit, and freshly cut grass. NZ Sauvignon Blanc is the Swiss Army knife of food wines — it cuts through richness and complements bright, herby dishes alike.

Sparkling Thyme Lemonade

A non-alcoholic sparkler made with fresh-squeezed lemon juice, thyme-infused simple syrup, and topped with cold sparkling water. Bright, herbal, and incredibly refreshing — the grown-up lemonade Elsie will love too.

Family Corner

Conversation starters, parenting nudges, and connection ideas

Parenting Corner

Seeing What's Really There

This week, the thermometer swings almost forty degrees — 84°F on Sunday, snow on Friday, 46°F on Saturday. Feelings will swing too: the giddiness of grilling in March, the restlessness of a rainy Monday, the buzz of theater night. Instead of labeling any of it good or bad, try something different: report what's happening like a weather forecaster — just the facts, with curiosity instead of judgment. When Elsie says she's 'bored' or 'fine,' gently dig: 'What's the weather like inside you right now — sunny, cloudy, stormy?' She's building emotional vocabulary this year, and this week's wild swings give her perfect raw material.

Dinner Conversation Starters

SUNDAY — GRILLED CHICKEN THIGHS W/ TABBOULEH & TURMERIC RICE

"We're grilling outside in March and it's 84 degrees — it feels like summer crashed the spring party! If you were a weather forecaster, but for feelings instead of weather, what would today's emotional forecast be for our family?"

Introduces the week's 'inside weather report' concept through play. The mismatch between March and 84°F is concrete proof that things aren't always what they seem — a natural Stoic opening for an 8-year-old. She's at the age where naming emotions precisely is a superpower she's actively building, and framing it as a forecast makes it feel fun, not therapeutic.

MONDAY — CORNED BEEF HASH WITH FRIED EGGS

"Rain makes everything look different outside — puddles, reflections, a gray sky that changes the color of everything. What's something in your life that looks one way on the outside but is actually something completely different when you really look at it?"

Connects the physical rain to the idea of looking beneath surfaces — the week's clarity theme. At 8, she's developing the cognitive ability to understand that appearances can deceive. This also gently touches on empathy: people may seem grumpy when they're actually tired, or quiet when they're thinking hard. It's a question that rewards slow thinking.

TUESDAY — BABO PASTA

"Every Tuesday we make pasta together — it's our thing. If someone filmed us making Babo Pasta and watched it like a documentary, what would they learn about our family that they couldn't learn any other way?"

The ritual of Babo Pasta is so familiar it's become invisible — this question asks her to see it freshly, as an outsider would. At 8, kids are developing theory of mind in more sophisticated ways — understanding how others perceive them. Reflecting on a family ritual from a camera's perspective builds both identity and gratitude for the small, repeated things that actually define a family.

WEDNESDAY — LEMON RICOTTA PANCAKES (BREAKFAST FOR DINNER)

"We're having pancakes for dinner — that's breakfast pretending to be dinner! What's something else that's way better when you put it in the wrong place or at the wrong time — like recess in the morning, or pajamas at the grocery store?"

Breakfast-for-dinner breaks a rule in the most delightful way. This question celebrates the joy of things being out of place and challenges her to think creatively about context. At 8, she's internalizing social rules about how things 'should' be — this playfully reminds her that the best stuff sometimes happens when you break the pattern. It also mirrors the week's wild weather, which is March acting like every season at once.

Conversation Starters (continued)

THURSDAY — CHICKEN & CORN STREET TACOS

"Quarter 3 ends tomorrow — that's like finishing a whole chapter of your school year. If your third quarter had a movie title, what would it be? And would it be a comedy, an adventure, a mystery, or something totally different?"

End-of-quarter is an abstract adult milestone, but reframing it as a movie title makes it concrete and fun. It invites her to synthesize three months of experience into a narrative — a high-level cognitive task she's now capable of at 8. The genre question reveals how she frames her own experience (comic? dramatic? heroic?) and gives you a window into how she sees her own story.

FRIDAY — PIZZA AT YAT THEATER (PARENTS' NIGHT OUT)

"You had your own evening tonight with your theater friends, and we had ours. Here's the challenge: describe your evening in exactly three facts — like a news reporter. No opinions, no 'it was so fun.' Just three things that happened. Then we'll do the same for ours."

This is the Stoic 'Fact Game' in action — and Friday is the perfect night for it. After a high-energy YAT evening, she'll naturally want to say 'it was amazing!' Pushing her to describe the facts underneath the fun (what she ate, who she sat with, what happened) builds observational skills and, surprisingly, produces richer stories. It also creates a sweet exchange: she shares her world, you share yours.

SATURDAY — UDON SOUP WITH SOUP DUMPLINGS

"It was 84 degrees on Sunday and 46 today — almost forty degrees different in one week! What's the biggest change YOU went through this week, from the beginning to right now? It doesn't have to be temperature — it could be a feeling, an idea, or something you learned."

The weather bookends the week perfectly — from extreme warmth to cozy cold. This question uses the temperature swing as a metaphor for personal change and invites her to reflect on her own week with the same clarity the Stoics practiced. At 8, kids are beginning to develop metacognition — the ability to think about their own thinking — and this question exercises exactly that muscle. Over warm udon on a cold day, it's a beautiful way to close the week.

Nudges

The Inside Weather Report

The week's weather swings from 84°F to snow, and the Stoic theme is about seeing what's actually happening. This creates a perfect opening for an emotional literacy ritual that feels like a game, not a therapy session.

Each morning and evening, do a quick 'inside weather report' as a family. Everyone reports their internal weather: 'I'm partly cloudy with a chance of excitement' or 'I'm a steady drizzle — kind of tired.' No fixing, no follow-up questions. Just report and acknowledge. Elsie will love the meteorologist role-play, and you'll get a daily read on her emotional state without asking the dreaded 'how are you feeling?'

1. Sunday morning, introduce it at breakfast before grilling: 'The weather outside is wild this week — 84 today, rain tomorrow, maybe snow Friday. Let's do our own forecast, but for feelings. I'll go first: I'm sunny with a light breeze — excited to grill.'
 2. Keep it to one sentence per person, no analysis. Just: 'What's your weather right now?' Morning and dinner, that's it.
 3. By Wednesday it'll be automatic. By Saturday, you'll have a week's worth of emotional data points — and Elsie will have practiced naming her feelings 14 times without it ever feeling like homework.
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The Monday Solo Mission

Dan has meetings from 3–8 PM on Monday — a long stretch where he can't be fully present. It's also rainy. Instead of treating this as a gap in the evening, frame it as a mission.

Before the meetings start, give Elsie a 'Solo Mission' — a special challenge she completes independently by the time Dad is free. Make it genuinely useful and slightly challenging: draw a floor plan of every room in the house from memory (including furniture), or create a 'family time capsule list' of 10 things that describe your family right now. The key is a concrete deliverable she can present at dinner.

1. Before your first meeting, sit with Elsie for 5 minutes: 'I've got a long work afternoon, but I have a mission for you. It's a solo mission — no help from anyone.'
 2. Write the mission on a sticky note and put it on the fridge. Be specific: 'Your mission: Draw a detailed map of our house from memory. Include every piece of furniture you can remember. Bonus: label your three favorite spots.'
 3. When you finish at 8 PM, the very first thing you do is ask to see the result — not 'how was your afternoon?' but 'Show me what you made.' This shifts the reunion from absence to accomplishment.
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The Quarter 3 Debrief

Friday marks the end of Quarter 3 — a milestone that school tracks but families rarely celebrate. Friday itself is packed (early release, YAT, parents' night out), so Saturday's cozy udon dinner is the perfect debrief moment.

Over Saturday's soup, do a mini 'quarter review' — not about grades, but about growth. Ask three questions slowly, giving her time to think between slurps of udon: (1) What's something you can do now that you couldn't do in January? (2) Who became more important to you this quarter? (3) What's one thing you want to try in Q4 that scares you a little? Write her answers on a notecard and put it on the fridge. In June, pull out all the quarter cards and watch her reaction.

1. Prepare the three questions before dinner — write them on a notecard so you remember the exact wording and don't improvise mid-soup
 2. Ask one question between courses or between dumplings. Don't rush. If she needs silence to think, let the silence work — it means the question landed
 3. After she answers all three, write them down together on a card: 'Elsie's Quarter 3 Report — March 2026.' Tape it to the fridge. Tell her you'll do this at the end of every quarter.
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Reflection

The Hundred Dresses by Eleanor Estes, illustrated by Louis Slobodkin

A quiet, powerful chapter book about Wanda Petronski, a girl who claims to have a hundred dresses at home — all lined up in her closet. Her classmates don't believe her and tease her relentlessly. The twist, when it comes, is devastating and beautiful: what was real was not what anyone assumed. At 73 pages, it's a perfect one-week read at bedtime. It won a Newbery Honor and has been teaching kids about empathy, assumptions, and the difference between seeing and judging for over eighty years. *This week's theme is about seeing what's really there — stripping away assumptions and looking clearly. The Hundred Dresses is the kid-sized version of that exact lesson. It asks: what if the thing you dismissed was actually the most extraordinary thing in the room? Read a chapter each night — by Saturday's udon dinner, she'll have a whole new lens for the 'Fact Game' and for how she sees the quiet kids in her own class.*

This week, the thermometer swings almost forty degrees. You'll grill in shorts on Sunday and wrap up in blankets on Saturday. Elsie will bounce from school to theater to pizza with friends to udon on the couch. Dan will power through a marathon meeting day. The week will feel like a lot — because it is. But here's what's easy to forget when you're in the middle of it: none of these moments need your interpretation. They don't need to be 'crazy' or 'exhausting' or 'amazing.' They just need you to be there, noticing. When Elsie reports her inside weather this week, she's not just playing a game. She's learning something most adults still struggle with: that feelings are temporary, that observing them is different from drowning in them, and that someone who asks 'what's your weather?' is someone who genuinely wants to know. You're teaching her that by asking. And somewhere in the asking, you might notice your own forecast shift — from busy to present, from planning to noticing, from parenting to simply being with her. That shift is the whole point.

You don't need to be a perfect parent — just a present one.

The Stoic Guide

CLARITY

What Is Actually Happening

When the week swings from 84°F to snow, from packed meetings to parents' night out, the mind writes stories faster than the weather changes. The Stoics practiced seeing things as they actually are — stripped of drama, fear, and excitement — and discovering that reality, unembellished, is always manageable.

"Always to define whatever it is we perceive — to trace its outline — so we can see what it really is: its substance. Stripped bare. As a whole. Unmodified."

— Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 3.11 (Gregory Hays translation)

This week, the weather will do something absurd. Sunday opens at 84 degrees — the kind of warmth that tricks you into thinking summer arrived early. By Friday, it's snowing. Saturday bottoms out at 46. If you tried to plan your wardrobe on Sunday, you'd be wrong by Thursday. If you panicked on Saturday, you'd forget you were in shorts three days ago. The weather, in other words, is doing exactly what the Stoics warned your mind does every day: swinging wildly between impressions that feel permanent but aren't. Marcus Aurelius, governing an empire through plague and war, returned again and again to a single discipline: see things as they are, not as they appear. In *Meditations* 3.11, he prescribed a method — define the thing in front of you, trace its outline, strip away everything that doesn't belong to it. A meeting is not an ordeal; it is a conversation with a colleague. A cold snap is not a betrayal of spring; it is 46 degrees. A child's performance is not your anxiety about her performance; it is a girl on a stage, doing her best. This week, with Monday packed with meetings and Friday bright with theater and a night out, the opportunities to practice are everywhere. Each day builds on the last: from noticing how quickly the mind embellishes, to testing those impressions, to finally seeing — with steady, clear eyes — what is actually happening. The Stoics didn't promise this would make life easier. They promised it would make life real.

SUNDAY The First Impression

The thermometer says 84. The mind says summer. But look closer: the calendar says March 22, the trees are barely budding, and the birds are as confused as you are. Today's practice is simple — notice the gap between what something feels like and what it actually is. Warmth in late March is not summer. It's just warmth.

Step outside and describe the day using only facts — temperature, sounds, what you see. No adjectives like 'beautiful' or 'strange.' Just what is.

*"It is not things that disturb us, but our judgments about things." — Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 5*

MONDAY The Weight You Added

You have a full afternoon — meetings from three until eight. The mind labels this 'overwhelming' before the first one starts. But strip it bare, as Marcus taught: you will sit in rooms and talk with people. That is all. The overwhelm is not in the calendar. It is in the story you wrote about the calendar.

Before your first meeting, write down what you expect the day to feel like. At night, write what it actually felt like. Compare the two.

*"We are more often frightened than hurt; and we suffer more in imagination than in reality." — Seneca, *Letters to Lucilius* 13*

Reflections & Practice

TUESDAY Testing the Impression

Epictetus taught his students a single essential practice: when an impression arrives — a worry, a desire, a judgment — do not accept it immediately. Say to it: 'Wait. Let me see who you are. Let me test you.' This week, the weather tests you with false signals and the calendar tests you with density. Today, practice the pause. One impression at a time.

Choose one moment today when you feel a strong reaction. Before you act, ask: 'Is this the thing itself, or is this my story about the thing?'

WEDNESDAY The Bare Facts

Marcus Aurelius had a peculiar habit: he would describe luxuries and pleasures in the plainest terms. Roasted meat is a dead animal. Purple robes are sheep wool dipped in shellfish blood. Not to drain the joy from life, but to see it clearly. Today, practice his method on something that worries you. Describe it in the simplest possible terms. Watch the worry shrink.

Take one thing that's been on your mind — a deadline, a conversation, a decision. Write it in one plain sentence, as Marcus would. No drama. Just what it is.

"Objective judgment, now, at this very moment. Unselfish action, now, at this very moment. Willing acceptance — now, at this very moment — of all external events. That's all you need." — Marcus Aurelius, Meditations 6.13

THURSDAY Seeing the Quarter End

Tomorrow is the last day of the third quarter. Elsie comes home early. A season of school — tests, friendships, routines — wraps up quietly. The mind wants to rush to evaluate: was it good? Was it enough? The Stoic slows down. Before you judge a thing, see it clearly. What actually happened these last ten weeks? Not the grade, not the worry — the actual days, the small growth, the effort given.

At dinner, each person shares one fact about this past quarter — something they actually did, not how they feel about it. One concrete fact each.

Reflections & Practice

FRIDAY Clear Joy

Clarity isn't only for hard things. Today, Elsie performs at YAT. Tonight, the parents go out. The temptation is to rush through joy — to photograph it instead of seeing it, to already be thinking about tomorrow's cold snap. The Stoic sees joy clearly: not clinging to it, not fearing its end, but being fully present to its actual texture. What does Elsie's face look like when she steps onto the stage? What does a quiet dinner with your partner actually feel like?

During one good moment today, stop and describe it to yourself in real time, like a slow-motion replay. Don't caption it for anyone. Just watch.

"True happiness is to enjoy the present, without anxious dependence upon the future." — Seneca, De Vita Beata 15

SATURDAY Snow in Spring

Yesterday was theater and warmth. Today, 46 degrees and the possibility of snow. The mind says 'this shouldn't be happening in late March.' But the weather doesn't consult your preferences. This is the week's final lesson: reality is not obligated to match your expectations. When you see things clearly — this is cold, this is Saturday, this is a day — there is nothing to resist. There is only what is.

Spend two minutes outside in the cold. Don't call it 'miserable' or 'refreshing.' Just feel it. Notice what your mind adds, and gently set those additions aside.

Practice Together

The Fact Game

After dinner one evening this week, go around the table. Each person describes their day using only facts — no feelings, no judgments, no 'good' or 'bad.' Just what happened. 'I woke up at 7. I ate toast. I had a math test. I talked to my friend.' Then discuss: what did your mind want to add? What's the difference between the facts and the story you tell about them?

Marcus Aurelius practiced this daily in his private journal — defining things by their substance, stripped of embellishment. He used this method as his primary tool for maintaining clarity under the immense pressure of governing the Roman Empire.

The Inside Weather Report

Imagine you're a weather reporter, but instead of the weather outside, you're reporting on the weather inside your head. Try it: 'Currently, there's a small storm of nervousness about my play. Partly cloudy with some excitement about getting out of school early. Light winds of wondering what's for dinner.' When you describe your feelings like weather, they feel less scary — because weather always passes.

The Stoics believed that our feelings are like clouds — they drift in, they look big, but they always move on. You don't have to believe everything a cloud tells you. You can just watch it pass.

The world will do what it does — swing from warm to cold, from busy to still, from worry to joy. Your only task is to see each thing for what it actually is. Not what it threatens to be, not what you wish it were. Just what it is. That is enough. That has always been enough.

The Weekly Read

1 articles clipped · Themes, reflections, and something fun

The Key That Unlocks Everything

At 3:30 AM on March 11, someone at Stryker — a company that makes the tools surgeons rely on to save lives — watched 200,000 devices simultaneously factory-reset themselves. The weapon wasn't a virus. It wasn't even malware. It was Microsoft Intune, Stryker's own device management platform, faithfully executing remote-wipe commands pushed by an attacker who'd stolen the right credentials. The Iran-linked group Handala didn't need to write a single line of exploit code. They just logged in as an admin and pressed the button that already existed. This is the part that should unsettle you: the attack worked **because** the system worked. Intune did exactly what it was designed to do — manage devices at scale, push commands instantly, execute without question. Fifty thousand employees idled. Surgical equipment supply chains froze. Paramedics in some regions lost access to the LifeNet system they use to transmit ECGs to hospitals, falling back to manual procedures that belong to a previous decade. Forester analyst Paddy Harrington insists this isn't an Intune flaw — it's a living-off-the-land attack that exploited credential theft and the absence of multi-admin approval for destructive actions. He's technically right. But "technically right" is cold comfort when the tool you trusted to protect your fleet is the thing that bricked it. The real question isn't whether Intune is secure. It's whether any system that grants a single administrator the power to wipe 200,000 devices should exist without a dead-man's switch.

Stryker attack raises concerns about role of device management tool *(cybersecurity, healthcare)*

The definitive early report on how an Iranian-linked group turned Microsoft's own device manager into a 200,000-endpoint wiper.

The Trojan Horse Never Left

The Stryker attack is shocking, but the pattern it reveals is ancient. In 1982, the CIA reportedly planted sabotaged software in code they knew the Soviets would steal for a Siberian gas pipeline. The pipeline's control systems — trusted infrastructure, running trusted code — eventually triggered the largest non-nuclear explosion ever recorded. The Soviets didn't import a bomb. They imported a tool that happened to contain one. Fast forward to 2010: Stuxnet infiltrated Iran's Natanz nuclear facility through legitimate-looking updates for Siemens industrial controllers. The centrifuges tore themselves apart while the monitoring dashboards showed everything was fine. In 2020, SolarWinds turned routine software updates into a backdoor that compromised thousands of organizations including U.S. government agencies. And for five years, China's Volt Typhoon group lived silently inside American critical infrastructure using nothing but PowerShell and Task Scheduler — tools every Windows admin uses daily. The thread connecting a wooden horse at the gates of Troy to a remote-wipe command in a Michigan medtech company is the same: trust is the attack surface. Not software. Not hardware. The implicit belief that the tools we depend on are acting in our interest. Security researcher communities now call this pattern "living off the land" — attackers don't bring weapons, they use yours. The uncomfortable dinner question: how many of the tools your family relies on daily — your phone's management profile, your router's firmware, your car's update system — have a wipe button that only needs one compromised password to activate?

Stryker attack raises concerns about role of device management tool *(cybersecurity, healthcare)*

The same article, read through a wider historical lens of trusted infrastructure becoming weapons.

The Through-Line: *A light week of reading — just one clipped article — but what an article. Sometimes a single story is a prism. The Stryker attack refracts into questions about trust, infrastructure, and the paradox of convenience: every tool powerful enough to help you at scale is powerful enough to destroy you at scale. The ancients understood this. We keep having to relearn it. Perhaps the real reading this week is the silence between the saves — the articles we didn't clip because we were too busy trusting the systems humming quietly in the background.*

The Dessert Course

Since we're talking about things that seem engineered but are entirely natural: wombats poop cubes. Actual cubes. Not spheres, not cylinders — six-sided, stackable cubes. Scientists at Georgia Tech finally figured out how in 2018: the last 8% of the wombat intestine has varying elasticity that shapes the output like a biological extrusion press. Why cubes? They don't roll away, making them perfect for marking territory on rocks and logs. Your move, 3D printers. Next time someone tells you nature isn't precise, remind them that a pudgy Australian marsupial solved a packaging problem that engineers still struggle with — and it does it about 100 times a day.

Source: Science Sensei / Georgia Tech Research

1 articles · March 22 – March 28, 2026

Bedtime Story

The Fort by the Stream

The Fort by the Stream

The morning Chelsie pedaled her bike to the edge of the Reston woods, the air felt like summer had arrived three months early — warm and golden, eighty-four degrees by breakfast, the kind of day that made staying inside feel almost criminal.

She parked her bike beside the old trail marker where the pavement ended and the dirt began. Sharkie peeked out from the top of her backpack, his button eyes catching the sun. "Ready?" Chelsie whispered. She always brought Sharkie on adventures. He was an excellent listener.

The trail smelled like wet earth and something sweet — wild honeysuckle, Daddio would have said, though Chelsie thought it smelled more like the lemon ricotta pancakes they'd had for dinner last Tuesday. She followed the path toward the stream, which she could hear before she could see it — louder than usual, rushing and tumbling over rocks with the kind of rhythm you could almost dance to. Snowmelt. All that late-March snow had to go somewhere.

That's when she noticed the stones.

Three flat rocks, arranged in a meticulous arrow on the trail, pointing left toward the stream bank. Chelsie stopped. She hadn't placed them. Nobody she knew had mentioned coming here. She looked closer and saw something else — bike tire tracks in the soft mud, thinner than hers, curving off the main path.

Someone else was in the woods.

She followed the arrow. The trail narrowed, and the stream appeared — wider than she remembered, the water quick and silver, catching light between the trees. A massive oak had fallen across it, its trunk dark with moss, bridging the gap like a balance beam over the rushing water.

Chelsie's stomach flipped. The water below wasn't deep, but it was fast — churning over stones, sending up little sprays of mist. She gripped Sharkie's fin through her backpack strap, steadied herself, and stepped onto the trunk.

One foot. Then the other. Arms out. Eyes forward.

The bark was rough under her sneakers. The water sang below her. Halfway across, a breeze pushed at her shoulders and she wobbled — but she kept her gaze on the far bank, where the mud was solid and the ferns grew thick, and she walked the rest of the way without looking down.

On the other side, another arrow of stones. And now she could hear something new — a rhythmic tapping, like someone fitting sticks together.

She pushed through a curtain of budding branches and found it: a fort.

Not a pile-of-sticks fort. A real one — walls woven from branches, a roof of layered bark, moss stuffed into the cracks like green mortar. It sat in a clearing right along the stream, the water gurgling past its back wall. Tiny purple wildflowers had been tucked into the gaps near the entrance like decorations.

A girl about Chelsie's age knelt beside the fort, fitting a long branch into the wall. She had mud on her knees and leaves in her hair and the focused expression of someone building something important. A bike helmet sat on a rock nearby.

The girl looked up.

For a moment, neither of them spoke. Chelsie felt that familiar pull — the one that makes you want to back away, pretend you didn't see, keep walking. The girl was a stranger. Strangers were uncertain. Uncertain felt uncomfortable.

But the fort was beautiful. And the girl had built it alone. And something about the way the sunlight fell through the new spring leaves — clear and warm, everything exactly as it was — made Chelsie see the moment plainly.

"Hi," Chelsie said. "I'm Chelsie. Your fort is amazing."

The girl's whole face changed — like a window swinging open.

"I'm Noor," she said. "I didn't think anyone would find the arrows." She grinned. "Do you want to help me finish the roof?"

They spent the rest of the afternoon together — balancing across two more fallen trees to gather bark from the far bank, splashing through the shallows to find flat stones for a doorstep, weaving ferns into the walls until the whole fort smelled like the woods itself. The stream kept up its rushing song beneath them every time they crossed, and Sharkie watched from a sunny rock, and by the time the shadows grew long and they pedaled their bikes home along the same trail, muddy and grinning, they had already planned to meet again on Thursday.

Walking through the front door that evening, mud on her elbows and a smile she couldn't stop, Chelsie realized something.

The bravest thing she did all day wasn't crossing the fallen tree over the rushing water. It was saying "hi" to someone she didn't know. Because sometimes a single small word is all it takes to find a wonderful new friend.

Has there ever been a time you almost didn't say hi to someone — but you're glad you did? What happened next?

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